

The AI Automation Playbook

Para-Inc // Edition 1.0 // A practical field guide for automating real work with free and low-cost tools.

1. Pick the right job to automate

Automate the work that is (a) repetitive, (b) rule-based, and (c) high-volume. Good first targets: file routing, email triage, invoice capture, social posting, lead enrichment, report generation. Never start by automating a process you have not done by hand at least three times.

2. The three-layer model

Trigger -> Logic -> Action. A trigger is an event (new email, cron time, webhook). Logic is a filter or branch (if subject contains 'invoice'). Action is the effect (save to folder, send message, call API). Every automation is this shape.

3. Free stack that actually works

- n8n (self-hosted, free): best general automation engine.
- Make (free tier): friendly visual builder.
- Zapier (free tier): largest app library.
- Local LLM via Ollama: free inference, no data leaves your machine.
- Cloudflared: free public tunnel to expose a local webhook.

4. Example: auto-file invoices by email

Trigger: Gmail 'new email in label=Invoices'

Logic: Extract PDF, ask local LLM: 'return JSON {vendor, amount, due}'

Action: Save row to Google Sheet + rename file to {vendor}_{amount}.pdf

5. 30-day plan

Week 1: list 10 repetitive tasks. Week 2: build 2 automations. Week 3: add error alerts (email on failure). Week 4: measure hours saved; reinvest them.

6. Failure modes

Silent failures are the killer. Always add a 'notify me on error' branch. Log every run. Keep a manual override. Start with non-destructive actions (copy, not move).